

Teach Back Tool

CMT: CMT-0017 (SR)

MCG Health
Shared Resources
28th Edition

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Introduction

Patient teach back is the process of having the patient "teach back" to the clinician the information and skills that the patient needs to perform self-care. This technique allows the clinician to assess the patient's and caregiver's understanding of the self-care instructions and the ability to perform self-care techniques. Teaching back the information and skills helps demonstrate to the clinician that the patient understands and is able to safely perform self-care when there is no direct clinical support available. Teach back can also close the understanding gaps between clinicians and patients, and professional caregivers and family caregivers. Once a gap in understanding is identified, additional teaching can be provided.(1)(2)(3)

Patient education considerations should be considered during the teach back process (eg, literacy, readiness for change); see Education: Patient, Family, and Caregiver  SR for more information.(3)(4) Clinicians should also be aware of and utilize teach back techniques, including: plan the teaching experience, use written materials and illustrations when available, clarify the patient's understanding by asking questions, and review the instructions again when the patient cannot restate the information.(5) The clinician should utilize humble inquiry to show the patient that the clinician is placing the accountability for poor understanding on themselves rather than the patient (such as, "I want to make sure that I explained things clearly").(6)

Every contact with the patient and family is an opportunity to impart health education.(7) Teach back through the continuum of care provides multiple opportunities for the clinician to review important healthcare information to increase patient and family recall and confidence.(8) This tool is designed for use by a clinician. It is divided into categories that may impact the patient and caregiver. Not every factor may be relevant for every patient; therefore, not every question in the assessment need be asked.

Teach Back Questionnaire

- **General questions(5)(9):**
 - Why did you go to the hospital?
 - What was your diagnosis?
 - What does this diagnosis mean?
 - What tests did you have in the hospital?
 - What did the tests show?
 - What medicines did you get in the hospital?
 - What were the medicines for?
- **Discharge preparation questions(5)(9):**
 - What are you going to do when you leave the hospital today?
 - Who are you supposed to call if you have questions or problems before your next doctor's appointment?
 - Can you explain what things you need to do to take care of yourself after you leave the hospital? Specific questions based on disease or condition status include:
 - Why do you need to do these things?
 - What changes do you need to make to the things you eat?
 - What changes do you need to make to how much fluid you drink?
 - What kind of activity did the doctor say you can do? What are you not supposed to do?
 - How and when should you change your bandage?
 - How and when should you drain your drain?
 - How and when should you care for your ostomy?
 - How and when should you weigh yourself?
 - How and when should you check your blood pressure?
 - How and when should you check your blood sugar?
 - How and when should you check your heart rate?
 - Do you know how to give yourself an injection?

- Do you know how to work your medical equipment (eg, oxygen tank, fold-up walker)?
 - What symptoms should you call your doctor with?
 - What symptoms should you get help right away with?
 - How do you take your medicines? (Ask patient to go through one medicine at a time.)
 - What is the name of your medicine?
 - What is the medicine taken for?
 - How much of the medicine do you take?
 - How often do you take this medicine?
 - Is there any medicine you were told to take that you are not taking? If yes, why?
 - Do you have a list of all the medicines you are taking?
 - What questions do you have?
- **Follow-up appointment questions(5)(9):**
 - When are you supposed to see your regular doctor?
 - Name of provider: _____
 - Date and time of appointment: _____
 - Are you supposed to see any other doctors after discharge? If so, what for and when?
 - 1. Name of provider: _____; Specialty: _____; Date and time of appointment: _____
 - 2. Name of provider: _____; Specialty: _____; Date and time of appointment: _____
 - 3. Name of provider: _____; Specialty: _____; Date and time of appointment: _____
 - 4. Name of provider: _____; Specialty: _____; Date and time of appointment: _____
 - 5. Name of provider: _____; Specialty: _____; Date and time of appointment: _____
 - Are you supposed to get any tests after you are discharged? If so, what for and when?
 - 1. Name of test: _____; Purpose of test: _____; Date and time of appointment: _____
 - 2. Name of test: _____; Purpose of test: _____; Date and time of appointment: _____
 - 3. Name of test: _____; Purpose of test: _____; Date and time of appointment: _____
 - 4. Name of test: _____; Purpose of test: _____; Date and time of appointment: _____
 - 5. Name of test: _____; Purpose of test: _____; Date and time of appointment: _____
 - When are you supposed to get the results of these tests?
 - At next provider appointment
 - In the mail in next 7 days
 - In the mail in more than 7 days
 - Don't know

Resources

- Additional information, resources, and tools include[A]:
 - After Hospital Care Plan from the Project Re-Engineered Discharge (RED) Toolkit, Boston Medical Center at www.bu.edu/fammed/projectred
 - Consumers, Taking Care of My Health Care from the National Transitions of Care Coalition at www.ntocc.org
 - How-to Guide: Improving Transitions from the Institute for Healthcare Improvement at www.ihl.org

References

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Footnotes

[A] There are many private and public resources and tools available to evaluate a patient's understanding of self-management and identify the need for additional education. Copyright or other permissions may be necessary prior to the use of these forms. Users should contact the sponsoring organization to obtain permission, if necessary. [A in Context Link 1]

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Last Update: 3/14/2024 1:13:56 AM
 Build Number: 28.1.20240313235330.016020